

The Troy-Amman Connection:

Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute and Prime Minister Hani Mulki

Final Paper



By: Paul Khoury

Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute

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Preamble

As a student whose college experience was characterized by a three-year stint in student government during which I had long been faced with the challenge of increasing involvement and decreasing apathy in a campus predominantly comprised of engineers, I had long pondered the relationship between politics, civic engagement, public service, and the engineer. Moreover, as someone who had grown up in New York City surrounded by youth-driven political advocacy, strong opinions, and outspoken progressivism, I had long found the relatively apolitical disposition of Rensselaereans to be curious.

This curiosity begot more curiosity: I wished to uncover if there was any history of RPI-trained engineers who went on to become important political figures. I sought to prove to myself that the two seemingly unrelated callings could coexist and unite in a single individual, and that such a man may have preceded me at dear old RPI. After all, Herbert Hoover, and to a lesser extent, Jimmy Carter were testaments to the fact that engineers have risen to even the highest office. And given RPI's long existence (on an American timescale anyway), I figured at least a few of our many successful alumni who went on to "change the world" via government instead of the most traditional RPI routes of technological innovation or military service.

Indeed, my research yielded a number of interesting results, including figures such as George Low and J. Erik Jonsson (an astute reader will recognize both as namesakes for particularly ugly buildings on campus), both of whom left unmistakable marks on American civic life as Director of NASA and mayor of Dallas, respectively. I also discovered a slew of US and State Representatives and senators – though most of the RPI alumni who had national roles were part of a graduating class beginning with "18-" – judges, directors of federal agencies, and

the author of the Appomattox Courthouse agreement whose signing is widely considered to have marked the end of the American Civil War.

Yet none struck me as profoundly as the man whose name I had shockingly never encountered: Dr. Hani Mulki, former Prime Minister of Jordan. Despite his stature, and despite earning his master's and doctoral degrees at RPI, his connection to the Institute and to the Capital Region is almost entirely absent from local historical memory.

This silence pointed to an unexplored local narrative. How had I, after years at RPI, never heard that a former head of state that had walked the same campus, lived on the same streets, and studied in the same buildings? Why was this history not spoken about neither at RPI nor in Troy's broader historical discourse?

For reasons I can only describe as naïve optimism, I wondered whether I might be able to learn more directly from the source. On a whim, I reached out to his son, Dr. Fawzi Mulki, on LinkedIn. To my astonishment, after a few days, I received a reply. He graciously agreed to a long-form interview about his father's life, education, and political career, and about the years the Mulki family spent in Troy.

The following history is therefore built primarily on that interview – an oral history with Dr. Fawzi Mulki, used here as a primary source¹ – and supplemented by secondary research into RPI archives and local media.

This paper explores whether Troy, NY, and RPI played an unexpected but meaningful role in shaping a global political leader. Supplementarily, it considers a question of longstanding personal interest: how an engineer's training can influence approaches to governance, diplomacy, conflict resolution, and statecraft.

In 1824, a disgraced lawyer by the name of Amos Eaton, acting under the patronage of the ultra-wealthy landowner Stephen van Rensselaer, established a school that would come to be known as Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute. This school was the first technical school established in the English-speaking world. Almost a century afterwards, the Anglosphere – at least to the extent that the extent of the British Empire can be considered a proxy for what is considered the Anglosphere – briefly expanded to include a land on the eastern banks of the Jordan river.

In the aftermath of World War I, Britain, alongside its ally France, sought to exploit the rapid decline of the “Sick Man of Europe,” the Ottoman Empire. To this end, the two powers encouraged, funded, and orchestrated the Great Arab Revolt, capitalizing both on longstanding resentment toward Ottoman rule and on the growing force of Arab nationalism. The revolt was led by Sharif Hussein of Mecca – sharif being an honorific title reserved for descendants of the Prophet Muhammad. In 1921, the Emirate of Transjordan was established, with Hussein’s son Abdullah installed as emir. By 1946, the United Nations formally recognized Jordan as an independent sovereign kingdom, and within a decade British troops completed their withdrawal, solidifying Jordanian sovereignty.

In the early 1950s, Abdullah’s grandson (Hussein’s great-grandson and the Prophet Muhammad’s fortieth-generation descendant) was studying in London. During this period, he became acquainted with the Jordanian ambassador to the United Kingdom, a diplomat by the name of Fawzi Mulki (note: due to convention for some Arabic surnames, his name is alternatively and interchangeably rendered both with the honorific family name modification *Al-Mulki*, or without it. *El-Mulki* is also a valid, semantically equivalent transliteration.). A friendship is forged in London, and a consequential political relationship with it. Due to a political tumult, the young student Hussein was proclaimed king in August 1952, succeeding to

the throne when he was just 16. Upon his assent, the young king appoints Fawzi, the diplomat from London, to the role of prime minister. This appointment would be the birth of a new Jordanian political dynasty. Over 60 years later, Prime Minister Fawzi Mulki's son, Hani Mulki, would be appointed to the same office as his father.

It is through this man, Hani Mulki, the 41st prime minister of Jordan, that the histories of the Kingdom of Jordan and the unassuming city of Troy, New York, intersect in a manner that is both unlikely and largely unexamined. Though almost entirely unknown to most residents of the Capital Region, to Trojans, or even to Rensselaereans, Mulki was educated at RPI between 1975 and 1979, earning his graduate degrees in engineering while living and working in Troy. He would go on to maintain enduring personal and familial ties to the city long after his departure. That a figure who played a significant role in modern Middle Eastern politics was, for a formative period of his life, shaped by an institution and a city so geographically and culturally distant invites further exploration. Moreover, it suggests that Troy's local history may be more globally entangled than is often presumed.

This paper advances the claim that Mulki's graduate education at RPI helped instill a distinctly engineering-oriented approach to governance. This paper also expounds on the many deeply personal relationships that shaped Mulki's time in the Troy area and focuses on the ones that stayed with him, from his American wife whom he met in RPI to the Professors such as Gene Simons, whose mentorship reinforced strong habits of systems engineering oriented thought. This paper also contends that Mulki's lived experience in Troy: studying intensely, living modestly, and embedding himself in a small post-industrial American city, is reflected in his personal traits that later defined his political career, such as restraint, humility, and an

aversion to political spectacle. Altogether, many of these experiences can help in explaining why Mulki approached politics not as a pursuit of power, but as technical problem-solving.

By the time Hani Mulki arrived in Troy in the early 1980s, the city was no longer the booming industrial hub it had once been. Troy's nineteenth-century prosperity which had stemmed from its manufacturing and its fortuitous waterways had long since given way to the broader deindustrialization that had affected many other Rust Belt cities. Importantly however, RPI remained.

Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute in the 1970s and 1980s occupied a distinctive position within American higher education. It was already well established as an elite engineering institution, with a reputation for rigor, applied science, and close ties to industry. While not as globally recognized as some larger or more prestigious universities, RPI nevertheless maintained a strong standing among technical schools, particularly in fields such as mechanical engineering, electrical engineering, and applied physics. According to Fawzi Mulki, RPI had some name recognition among educated Jordanians in the '70s and '80s, albeit to a limited extent.

Though he was the son of a former Prime Minister, Mulki's decision to attend RPI was facilitated, like so many of us, by a scholarship. His choice to attend was a practical and financially responsible one rather than an expression of prestige or political inheritance. In 1975 Mulki would move to New York to begin his PhD in Industrial and Systems Engineering, which he completed in four years, in 1979.

Campus culture at RPI during this period reflected the Institute's priorities. Much like it remains today, the curriculum was heavily focused on engineering, with little emphasis on political science or any humanities for that matter, especially at the graduate level. As later oral

testimony suggests, Mulki's experience at RPI was defined far more by research projects than by formal campus organizations or political engagement.

Central to this educational experience was his mentorship under Professor Gene Simons, his advisor who left a lasting impression on Mulki. Simons was the associate dean of the school of management and industrial engineering whose research centered around decision-making science and information technology². Mulki's 180-page thesis, *A system design for the distribution of solar desalinized water to agricultural sites*³, combines his expertise in systems with altruistic engineering goals in a context clearly relevant to his homeland, where water scarcity is persistent an issue and a significant portion of drinking water relies on desalination⁴. Anecdotally, Mulki recounts that he emphasized reference-based thinking over memorization, urging students to free cognitive bandwidth for higher-order problem solving. This pedagogical philosophy would later echo in Mulki's approach to governance and diplomacy. Mulki and Simons personal and academic relationship would persist long after Mulki was awarded his degree, lasting up until Simons' death in 2005, with Simons even visiting Jordan on several occasions.

In addition to coursework, Mulki participated in collaborative projects with faculty tied to industrial research, including work connected to General Electric in nearby Schenectady, NY. These experiences first exposed him to large-scale energy systems and industrial challenges and gave him hand-on, practical exposure that RPI has prided itself in since its founding. He would later directly apply this experience to work on energy and water systems in Jordan.

There were a few meaningful exceptions to Mulki's otherwise academically and professionally focused routine. Socially, Mulki's life in Troy was shaped less by campus organizations and more by family ties, academic peers, and the small Arab community in the

Capital Region. He was not involved in fraternities or student government, nor did he pursue political engagement during his student years. Instead, his social world was relatively contained.

While the Arab population of Troy and the broader Capital Region at the time was modest in size, it was nonetheless present. According to oral history, Lebanese families in particular formed a visible community that was connected through small businesses and extended family networks. According to oral history, Jordanian and Algerian families were fewer in number but socially intertwined with this broader Arab diaspora. Families such as the Rabadi family, whose catering business and restaurant served Middle Eastern food in the Albany area, played an outsized role for the graduate student Mulki. Such establishments offered Mulki cultural familiarity and a sense of continuity. These were not enclaves of politicking or ideological discourse, but simple spaces of hospitality and likely a break from studies. In this respect, Troy is a city small enough to foster close ties, yet diverse enough to sustain immigrant identities.

Perhaps the most consequential social tie Mulki formed in Troy was also the most personal. During his time at RPI, he met Sheila Grande, a Troy native who was then working in the Institute's registrar's office while he was completing his doctoral studies⁵. Sheila herself was deeply rooted in the city: born, raised, and educated in Troy, a graduate of Troy High School, and later a student at Mildred Elley Business School⁶. In addition, her mother worked at RPI's computer center. Through his marriage, RPI ceased to be merely the site of Mulki's technical training and became entwined with his personal and family life.

While still in Troy, Mulki's housing arrangement with Sheila reflected a common situation for students at RPI: he spent time in married student housing on Burdett Avenue before later moving to a private residence on 15th Street. Following his graduation, the two married in

Amman and moved to Jordan, where Sheila would go on to navigate an international life as the wife of a diplomat and later a prime minister. Yet despite decades abroad, she, and by extension Hani Mulki and their future family, maintained strong ties to the Capital Region, returning frequently for extended visits and sustaining close relationships with family and friends in Troy. In this sense, Sheila Mulki served as a bridge between Troy and Amman.

Perhaps most telling of Mulki's connection to Troy is frequency of his return, even long after Mulki left as a student. His children, including his son Fawzi, spent nearly every summer in Troy for almost two decades, visiting their mother's family and simply enjoying the tempered weather and lake activities characteristic of summers in Upstate New York.

Upon returning to live and work in Jordan following his studies at RPI, Mulki applied his engineering training to national challenges, particularly in renewable energy and water infrastructure. His work on Jordan's first solar farm exemplifies this. Undertaken in remote areas and aimed at providing electricity and water access, the project was technically demanding but politically consequential. This project drew the attention of Crown Prince Hassan and put Mulki on the Jordanian political establishment's radar.

From this point forward, Mulki's career followed a gradual and largely technocratic progression rather than a conventional political ascent. After earning his PhD in Industrial and Systems Engineering at RPI, he served as Director of the Solar Energy Research Center before moving into leadership roles that increasingly veered toward policy. He became Executive Director of the General Islamic Academy of Sciences of the Organization of Islamic Cooperation, and later President of Jordan's Royal Scientific Society, while simultaneously serving as Secretary-General of the Higher Council for Science and Technology⁷. These positions placed him at an important position in national decision-making, without requiring the

typical entry into partisan politics. Later he assumed ministerial roles overseeing supply, industry and trade, energy and mineral resources, and water and irrigation. Arguably, these all closely aligned with his engineering background. His subsequent appointments as ambassador to Egypt and permanent representative to the Arab League represented deviations from this engineering trajectory and could be seen as his first forays in diplomacy. Throughout this progression, oral testimony suggests that Mulki neither actively pursued the office of Prime Minister nor resisted it; rather, he viewed political leadership as a responsibility that followed from competence and institutional trust, not as an end in-and-of-itself.

Mulki's engineering mindset would later prove instrumental during the Jordan–Israel peace negotiations. As part of the negotiating team, he applied geometric reasoning to resolve border demarcation disputes in the Gulf of Aqaba. By employing the concept of a locus of points, an idea rooted in engineering mathematics, he helped reconcile competing legal interpretations of maritime borders. This episode illustrates how his technical training shaped his approach to diplomatic problem solving in a very direct way.

This same engineering sensibility, however, extended beyond Mulki's technical approach to diplomacy and into the way he understood political responsibility itself. The habits of restraint and pragmatism, cultivated through engineering training, shaped not only how he operated as a leader, but how he chose to live a principled life as a public servant.

Mulki's modest lifestyle as a student stands in stark contrast to the privileges later available to him as a senior government official. Yet, as oral testimony makes clear, he carried forward the sensibilities formed during these years with remarkable consistency. Even after assuming high office, he resisted many of the ceremonial and material trappings of political power. He declined to move into the official prime ministerial residence, minimized the presence

of security details around his home, and avoided motorcades, road closures, and overt displays of authority whenever possible. When traveling, he preferred to pass through airports like any other passenger rather than through separate terminals reserved for political elites, and he resisted efforts by staff to spend government taxpayer money on personal luxuries. These choices were not performative gestures, but reflections of a deeply held belief that public office should not fundamentally alter the way one lives. His overall philosophy is captured succinctly in a maxim he reportedly related to his children: one should “live at the standard you can maintain when the bubble bursts.”

This ethic extended beyond daily habits to questions of professional integrity. Mulki was adamant, on principle, that once one has served at a senior level in government, one should not ever cross back into the private sector in ways that could create conflicts of interest or even the appearance of impropriety. Despite numerous opportunities to assume lucrative, he consistently refused them. To do otherwise, he believed, would compromise both personal integrity and public trust.

In conclusion, this paper has argued that Rensselaer Polytechnic Institute played a formative role in shaping a prime minister whose decisions influenced both Jordanian domestic policy and broader Middle Eastern diplomacy, even as this history remains largely absent from Troy’s local history. In tracing Hani Mulki’s path from graduate student in Troy to head of government in Jordan, Troy emerges as an exporter in the global technical knowledge economy by means of RPI. In particular, RPI functioned as part of a broader transnational pipeline in which foreign governments send privileged or promising students abroad to US universities to acquire advanced training and return home equipped to address national challenges⁸.

For myself, as an engineering student at RPI, uncovering this overlooked story underscores the value of local history in revealing the ostensibly “more important” global trajectories that pass quietly through familiar places. It is a reminder that the significance of a city or institution is not always measured by what is immediately visible, but also by its connections and intersections with other histories.

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